

THE DISTINCTION OF ESSENCE AND EXISTENCE IN AVICENNA'S METAPHYSICS: THE TEXT AND ITS CONTEXT*

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In his groundbreaking monograph *Avicenna and the Aristotelian Tradition* and in many other magisterial essays, Dimitri Gutas has underscored the key role that metaphysics plays in Avicenna's philosophical system.¹ Gutas' account of metaphysics (as well as of the other main philosophical disciplines), in Avicenna's *œuvre* is based on a full fledged methodology resulting from the critical evaluation of the assumptions of previous scholarship, an insightful analysis of the fundamental texts, and a thorough reconstruction of their doctrinal and historical context. All scholars interested in Avicenna's metaphysics (not to say of his psychology, noetics and epistemology) and Arabic metaphysical speculation in general, can only be thankful to Gutas' pioneering research for having explored and mapped what had been, to a large extent, virgin territory and for having provided a solid, brilliant and comprehensive outline of the whole, thus paving the way to subsequent, more specific investigations.

As a sign of personal heartfelt gratitude and in the footsteps of Gutas' masterly approach outlined above, the present contribution wishes to provide the analysis of a crucial issue of Avicenna's metaphysics. The

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¹ D. Gutas, *Avicenna and the Aristotelian Tradition. Introduction to Reading Avicenna's Philosophical Works* (Leiden: Brill, 1988). Cf. Id., "Ibn Tufayl on Ibn Sina's Eastern Philosophy," *Oriens*, 34 (1994), 222–41; "The Heritage of Avicenna: The Golden Age of Arabic Philosophy, 1000–ca. 1350", in *Avicenna and His Heritage*, eds. J. Janssens and D. De Smet (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 2002), 81–97; "The Logic of Theology in Avicenna," in *Logik und Theologie, Das Organon im arabischen und im lateinischen Mittelalter*, eds. D. Perler and U. Rudolph (Leiden: Brill, 2005), 59–72.

issue in question is the famous doctrine of the distinction of essence and existence, as expressed in Avicenna's masterpiece on metaphysics, the *Ilāhīyāt* (*Science of Divine Things*) of the *Kitāb aš-Šifā'* (*Book of the Cure*). The present paper will discuss the state-of-the-art, the most relevant textual evidence, and the main features of this doctrine in its context. Avicenna's distinction of essence and existence in created beings is well known: a triangle or a horse, for example, have a determinate essence (to be a three-sided geometrical figure, to be a four-legged solid-hoofed animal with flowing mane and tail, respectively), regardless of their existence in external reality or in the human mind. In the *Ilāhīyāt*, the doctrine in question represents the core element of the more general treatment, in chapter I, 5, of the primary concepts "existent" and "thing", and of their mutual relationship. Since "existent" and "thing" are *grosso modo* equivalent to the notions of "item having existence" and "item having essence" respectively, the account of their distinction (and connection) in this chapter encompasses, in its turn, the distinction of essence and existence.

1. *The Distinction of Essence and Existence: The Current State of Research*

The scholarship on this doctrine is abundant and has a long history, which cannot be accounted for in detail here.²

[...]

² The major study is now R. Wisnovsky, *Avicenna's Metaphysics in Context* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2003, henceforth: Wisnovsky [2003]). Among recent studies, see also Th.-A. Druart, "Shay' or 'res' as Concomitant of 'Being' in Avicenna," *Documenti e Studi sulla Tradizione Filosofica Medievale* 12 (2001), 125–42 (henceforth: Druart [2001]); P. Porro, "Universaux et *esse essentialia*: Avicenne, Henri de Gand et le «troisième Reich»,", in *Le réalisme des universaux*, Cahiers de philosophie de l'université de Caen, 38–39, (Caen: Presses universitaires de Caen, 2002), 10–50; O. Lizzini, "Wujūd-Mawjūd/Existence-Existent in Avicenna: A key ontological notion of Arabic philosophy," *Quaestio* 3 (2003), 111–38; M. Rashed, "Ibn 'Adi et Avicenne: sur les types d'existants", in *Aristotele e i suoi esegeti neoplatonici. Logica e ontologia nelle interpretazioni greche e arabe*, Atti del convegno internazionale, Roma, 19–20 ottobre 2001, eds. V. Celluprica, C. D'Ancona, and R. Chiaradonna, Napoli: Bibliopolis, 2004, 107–71 (henceforth: Rashed [2004]).

2. *The Main Text in Metaphysics: Ilāhīyāt I, 5*

That *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 is the main text of Avicenna on the relationship of “thing” and “existent”, essence and existence, is evident from several points of view. In terms of content, in this chapter these two pairs of notions are not simply touched upon or applied to a certain theme, as happens elsewhere, but are also analyzed in detail, so that the exposition here is much more extensive than in the other texts. In terms of position within the overall work, moreover, this chapter occurs at the beginning of the *Ilāhīyāt* and precedes the resumptions of the same topic in the following portion of the work, so that many of the subsequent *loci* refer back explicitly to it. The main topics of chapter I, 5 can be outlined as follows:⁹

⁹ *Aš-Šifāʾ, al-Ilāhīyāt* (1), eds. Ğ. Š. Qanawātī and S. Zāyid (Cairo: al-Hayʾa al-ʿĀmma li-Šuʿūn al-Maṭābīʿ al-Amīriya, 1960); *aš-Šifāʾ, al-Ilāhīyāt* (2), eds. M. Y. Mūsā, S. Dunyā, and S. Zāyid (Cairo: al-Hayʾa al-ʿĀmma li-Šuʿūn al-Maṭābīʿ al-Amīriya, 1960). The division of the chapter into sections, and the titles given to each section, are mine (see *Libro della Guarigione, Le Cose Divine di Avicenna (Ibn Sīnā)*, a cura di A. Bertolacci [Turin: UTET, 2007], 181–195). For a cursory analysis of this chapter, see Rahman [1958], 4–9; its overall English translation and systematic commentary is available in M. E. Marmura, “Avicenna on Primary Concepts in the Metaphysics of his al-Šifāʾ,” in *Logos Islamikos*, *Studia Islamica in Honorem G. M. Wickens*, eds. R. M. Savory and D. A. Agius (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies,

Outline 1: Contents of *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5

- [1] The primary concepts in general (pp. 29.5–30.2)
 - [1.1] “Existent”, “thing” and “necessary” as primary concepts (p. 29.5–6)
 - [1.2] The primary concepts as the first principles of the activity of conceptualizing (pp. 29.7–30.1)
 - [1.3] Proof of the necessity of the primary concepts (p. 30.1–2)
- [2] “Existent” and “thing” (pp. 30.3–32.5)
 - [2.1] “Existent” and “thing” cannot be defined: examples of pseudo-definitions of “existent” and “thing” (pp. 30.3–31.2)
 - [2.1.1] “Existent”, “thing” and “one” as primary and universal concepts (p. 30.3–4)
 - [2.1.2] The primary concepts cannot be defined (p. 30.4–6)
 - [2.1.3] Examples (pp. 30.6–31.2)
 - [2.2] Distinction between “existent” and “thing” (pp. 31.2–32.2)
 - [2.2.1] First formulation (p. 31.2–9)
 - [2.2.2] Second formulation (pp. 31.10–32.2)
 - [2.3] “Existent” is an inseparable concomitant of “thing” (p. 32.3–5)
- [3] Criticism of the opinion according to which “thing” can be absolutely non-existent (pp. 32.6–34.9)
 - [3.1] A “thing” cannot be non-existent both in the mind and in the external reality (p. 32.6–11)
 - [3.2] The absolutely non-existent cannot be enunciated (pp. 32.12–33.11)
 - [3.2.1] First argument (pp. 32.12–33.1)
 - [3.2.2] Second argument (p. 33.1–11)
 - [3.3] The absolutely non-existent cannot be known: only the non-existent that does not exist in external reality but exists in the mind can be known (p. 33.12–5)
 - [3.4] Explanation of the adversaries’ error (pp. 33.16–34.9)
- [4] Rejection of the opinion according to which “existent” and “thing” are not equivalent to their synonyms, and the attribute of a thing can be neither an existing thing nor a non-existing thing (p. 34.9–14)

- [4.1] Recapitulation (p. 34.9–10)
- [4.2] Exposition of the opinion and criticism (p. 34.11–4)
- [5] “Existent” is predicated according to priority and posteriority, and can be taken into account by a science (pp. 34.15–35.2)
- [6] “Necessary”, “possible”, “impossible” (pp. 35.3–36.6)
 - [6.1] “Necessary”, “possible” and “impossible” cannot be defined properly: mutual circularity of their definitions (pp. 35.3–36.3)
 - [6.2] Priority of “necessary” with regard to “possible” and “impossible” (p. 36.4–6)
- [7] Criticism of the opinion according to which what has ceased to exist can be brought back to existence (p. 36.6–19)
 - [7.1] Exposition of the opinion (p. 36.6–8)
 - [7.2] First criticism (p. 36.8–11)
 - [7.3] Second criticism (p. 36.11–9)

Avicenna's view on the relationship of “thing” and “existent”, essence and existence, is contained *in nuce* in parts [2.2] and [2.3] of the chapter, whose translation is provided in Text 1. Part [2.2] deals with the distinction of these concepts, part [2.3] with their connection. In part [2.2], “existent” and “thing” are distinguished by showing that each of them conveys a different notion, according to two consecutive formulations. Avicenna's general strategy is to clarify the meaning of “existent” and “thing” by associating them, respectively, with the notion of “existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality]” and the notion of “essence”, stated to be different from each other (main point of the first formulation, [2.2.1]); and then to argue for the distinction of these two notions by means of the analysis of propositions: since statements connecting essence (as subject) with real existence (as predicate) are informative (“synthetical” in a Kantian sense), these two entities must be distinct from one another (main point of the second formulation, [2.2.2]). The two formulations differ from one another not only in content, as we are going to see, but also in emphasis: the first gives precedence to “existent” over “thing”, whereas the second focuses primarily on “thing”, leaving “existent” in the background. Section [2.3], finally, affirms that, notwithstanding their distinction, “existent” is inseparable from “thing”, since things always exist in some way or another, and are always, therefore, existents.

Text 1: Avicenna, *Ilāhiyāt* I, 5, pp. 31.2–32.5 [pp. 34.50–36.83]¹⁰
(= Outline 1 [2.2–3])

[2.2 *Distinction between “existent” and “thing”, 2.2.1 First formulation*]

[a] We say that the notion (*ma'nā*) of ‘existent’¹¹ and the notion of ‘thing’ are conceptualized in the soul as two [distinct] notions.

[b] ‘Existent’, ‘established [in reality]’ (*muṭbat*) and ‘realized’ (*muḥaṣṣal*) are synonyms [that signify] a single notion. We have no doubt that their notion is already present in the soul of the reader of this book.

[c] With ‘thing’ and its equivalents another notion is signified in every language. For every entity (*amr*) has an essence (*ḥaqīqa*) by means of which it is what it is. Thus the triangle has as [its] essence the fact of being triangle, and the whiteness has as [its] essence the fact of being whiteness.

[d] This is what we call sometimes ‘proper existence’ (*wuḡūd ḥāṣṣ*). We do not mean by it the notion of existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality] (*wuḡūd iṭbātī*). For also by means of the term ‘existence’ many notions are signified, one of which is the essence according to which a thing is. That according to which [a thing] is, therefore, is like its proper existence.

[2.2.2 *Second formulation*]

[a] Let us go back [to the beginning]. We say to be clear that every thing has a proper essence, which is its quiddity (*māhiya*). Now, it is known that the proper essence of every thing is other than the existence that is synonymous with ‘being established [in reality]’ (*iṭbāt*).’

[b] For, if you say: ‘The essence so-and-so is existent in the concrete objects, or in souls, or absolutely (including [in this last case] the [previous] two¹²),’ this [statement] has a meaning that is ascertained and comprehensible. If, on the other hand, you said: ‘The essence so-and-so is the essence so-and-so,’ or: ‘The essence so-and-so is an essence,’ you would have a useless redundancy speech. If you said: ‘The essence so-and-so is a thing,’ [this] would be again a statement that does not inform regarding what is unknown (even less informative would be your statement: ‘The essence is a thing’), unless you mean by ‘thing’ ‘existing [thing],’ as if you were saying: ‘The essence so-and-so is an existing essence.’

[c] When you say: ‘The essence A is a thing, and the essence B is another thing,’ this [statement] is correct and informative only because

¹⁰ Numbers between square brackets refer to pages and lines of the critical edition of the Latin translation of the *Ilāhiyāt*: Avicenna Latinus, *Liber de Philosophia prima sive Scientia divina*, I–IV. Édition critique par S. Van Riet. Introduction par G. Verbeke (Louvain-Leiden: Peeters-Brill, 1977); *Liber de Philosophia prima sive Scientia divina*, V–X. Édition critique par S. Van Riet. Introduction par G. Verbeke (Louvain-Leiden: Peeters-Brill, 1980).

¹¹ *mawḡūd* (*wuḡūd* ed.)

¹² *yahummuhumā* (*yahummuhā* ed.)

you assume in your mind that [the essence B] is another determinate thing, different from this other thing [i.e. the essence A], as if you said: 'The essence A is a [certain] essence,¹³ and the essence B is another essence.' Without, at the same time, this assumption [of difference], and this conjunction [of the essence B with the essence A], [this statement] would not be informative.

[d] With 'thing', therefore, this notion is meant.

[2.3 'Existent' is an inseparable concomitant of 'thing']

[a] The concomitance (*luzūm*) of the meaning of 'existent'¹⁴ does not separate itself (*lā yufāriqu*) from it [i.e. from the notion of 'thing'] at all (*al-battata*). On the contrary, the notion of 'existent' always (*dā'iman*) accompanies it inseparably (*yalzamu*), since it [i.e. 'thing'] is either an existent in the concrete objects, or an existent in the estimative faculty and the intellect.

[b] Were it not so, it would not be a thing.

In the first formulation ([2.2.1]), Avicenna argues for the distinction between "existent" and "thing", announced in section [a], by adducing some synonyms of "existent" which are not synonyms of "thing", and connecting "thing" with a notion (having an essence) to which "existent" is unrelated. In section [b], "existent" is said to be a synonym of "established [in reality]", and "realized". Avicenna says that its meaning, as well as the meaning of its synonyms, is well-known, but he does not clarify the matter further. In section [d], however, he introduces the notion of "existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality]," a notion that is certainly related to "existent", insofar as it is the combination of "existence" and one of its synonyms. I call it "existence"¹⁵. In the case of "thing" on the other hand, the synonyms do not receive special attention, since they have been already taken into account in the previous section of the chapter (see above, Outline 1 [2.1]).¹⁶ Rather than being explained by means of synonyms, the notion of "thing" is analyzed and related in section [c] to the idea of having an "essence".¹⁶ In section [d], however, the essence is named "proper existence" (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ*), according to one of the many senses of existence, in distinction from the "existence regarding the fact of

¹³ *inna ḥaqīqatan ā ḥaqīqatun (inna ḥaqīqatan ā ed.)*

¹⁴ *mawğūd (wuğūd ed.)*

¹⁵ Only one of them ("entity", *amr*) is mentioned *en passant* in section [c].

¹⁶ The example of the triangle to elucidate the possess of an essence by the "thing" echoes the example chosen by Aristotle in *An. Post. A*, 1 to explain the necessity of a preliminary knowledge of the meaning of the expressions indicating the objects of teaching and science.

being established [in reality]” typical of “existent”. I call it “existence²”. By “proper existence” Avicenna apparently means the concrete way of existing proper to a determinate species of realities, conveyed by their distinctive essence. Avicenna thus affirms a fundamental distinction within existence:

Outline 2: The two meanings of existence in *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 [2.2.1d]

existence¹ = existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality]

existence² = proper existence = essence

This distinction of two meanings of existence can be found exclusively in the first formulation. The choice of linking both “existent” and “thing” with two senses of the same notion (existence) is apparently awkward and counter-productive, since it compromises the intended distinction of the two concepts and makes a second, more straightforward formulation of the issue necessary; however it is surely intentional, given its background in Aristotle and previous Arab philosophers¹⁷ and the widespread presence of the notion of “proper existence”, and similar expressions, within the *Ilāhīyāt*.¹⁸ As we are going to see, it is highly significant (cf. below, section 4).

The second formulation ([2.2.2]) equates the distinction between “thing” and “existent” to that between essence and existence¹, clarifying

¹⁷ Both the idea that existence is said in many ways, and the denomination of essence as “proper existence”, have a remote background in Aristotle’s doctrine of being and essence (see, respectively, *Metaph.* Γ, 2, 1003a33: “Being is said in many ways”, and 1003b32–33: “the essence of everything... is from its very nature something that is”; cf. Bertolacci [2006], 378. A link between essence, on the one hand, and being or existence, on the other, was affirmed by al-Kindī (d. after 256/870)—see the idea that an essence has its own being (“being of essence”, *kawn dāt*) in *Falsafa Ūlā, Rasā’il al-Kindī al-falsafiya*, ed. M. ‘A. Abū Rīda (Cairo: Dār al-Fikr al-‘Arabī, 1950–1953), vol. I, 41.3—and was neatly assessed by Yahyā ibn ‘Adī (d. 363/974)—see the expression “essential existence” (*wuğūd dātī*), which is regarded as typical of his “Platonization of Farabism”, i.e. his failure to distinguish spatio-temporal existence from entitative subsistence, and the ascription to essence of a kind of spatio-temporal existence (Rashed [2004], 146–7). What is peculiar of Avicenna is the denomination of essence as “proper existence” (a denomination possibly directed against Yahyā ibn ‘Adī’s Platonism).

¹⁸ I, 1, p. 9.1 (*wuğūd alladī yaḥuṣṣu*); I, 6, p. 37.18 (*wuğūd alladī yaḥuṣṣu*); p. 41.16 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ*); p. 41.16–7 (*wuğūd alladī yaḥuṣṣu*); II, 3, p. 74.14, 15 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ muta-qawwim*); p. 75.3 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ yataqawwamu bi-hī*); p. 75.6 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ*); p. 75.7 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ yataqawwamu bihī*); III, 10, p. 159.17 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ*); VIII, 5, p. 350.2 (*wuğūd ḥāṣṣ*); VIII, 6, p. 356. 9 [p. 413.84] (*ḥuṣūṣiyat wuğūd*). The expression “proper essence” is comparatively rare in Avicenna’s works.

this second distinction with a more coherent terminology. In section [a], Avicenna calls the essence “proper *essence*” and “quiddity”, and maintains that proper essence is different from existence¹—this latter being named by means of an expression (“existence synonymous with ‘being established [in reality]’”) that is equivalent to the one already employed in the previous section to denote the concept “existent”. The different terminology (“proper essence” instead of “proper existence”) is probably meant to avoid any confusion between essence and existence¹, even though the fact that existence¹ is specified as the existence that is synonymous with “being established [in reality]” implies that a wider notion of “existence” is still implicitly present.

The distinction between essence and existence¹ is argued for by means of the analysis of five propositions in section [b]. Both this section and the following one ([c]) have no parallel in the first formulation:

Outline 3: Propositions in Text 1 [2.2.2b]

- (1) “The essence so-and-so is existent in the concrete objects, or in the souls, or absolutely [i.e both in the concrete objects and in the souls, or: either in the concrete objects or in the souls]” = informative statement
- (2) “The essence so-and-so is the essence so-and-so” = tautology
- (3) “The essence so-and-so is an essence” = tautology
- (4) “The essence so-and-so is a thing” = not informative, unless “thing” is meant as “existing [thing]” → (4a) “The essence so-and-so is an existing thing” = informative
- (5) “The essence is a thing” = even less informative [unless “thing” is meant as “existing [thing]” → (5a) “The essence is an existing thing” = informative]

The distinction of essence and existence¹ is attested by the comparison of proposition [1] with propositions [2]–[3]. In proposition [1], the essence is said to be existent according to at least one of the two modes of existence¹, namely existence in external objects or in the mind, and this predication of existence results in being informative. This is so because the notion of the predicate (“is existent”, namely “has existence”) is not already contained in the notion of the subject (“essence”). In propositions [2]–[3], on the other hand, the notion of the predicate is identical, either completely or partially, with the notion of the subject, and these statements are therefore tautological. Propositions

[4]–[5] present the same opposition with regard, respectively, to the stated proposition [4a] and the unstated proposition [5a]; in these latter “existent” is not the entire predicate, as in proposition [1], but an adjective attached to it (“existing essence” or “existing thing”).

In section [c] Avicenna adds a sixth proposition, which—albeit directly relevant neither to the distinction of essence and existence, nor to the clarification of the meaning of “thing”—aims at countering the possible objection that there are informative statements in which “thing” is predicated of “essence”, without including existence.

- (6) “The essence A is a thing, and the essence B is another thing” = informative, if “another” is understood not simply as “distinct”, but as “different”, and as expressing difference with regard to the previously mentioned “thing” → (6a) “The essence A is a [certain] essence, and the essence B is another essence.”

Although in propositions [4]–[6] the terms “thing” and “essence” are sometimes used interchangeably,¹⁹ these propositions also attest that “thing” and “essence” are, according to Avicenna, two distinct concepts. The very presence of proposition [4] as distinct from proposition [3] implies that “thing” and “essence” have, according to Avicenna, different meanings, since otherwise the former proposition (“The essence so-and-so is a thing”) would be identical to the latter (“The essence so-and-so is an essence”). Accordingly, Avicenna states that proposition [3] is a mere tautology, whereas he says that proposition [4] is not informative (“it does not inform about what is unknown”).

In section [2.3], Avicenna goes back to the relationship between “existent” and “thing”. He makes clear that, despite the different meanings of these two concepts, and despite the distinction between existence¹ and essence, the concept of “existent” accompanies inseparably the concept of “thing”. The infinitive *luzūm* and the verb *lazima* in section [a] attest that Avicenna regards “existent” as a *lāzim* of “thing”, namely a notion that, albeit not being part of the essence of something is also not a bare accident, but something approaching the

¹⁹ In proposition [4a] (“The essence so-and-so is an existing *essence*”), for example, the term “essence” takes the place of the term “thing” in proposition [4] (“The essence so-and-so is a *thing*”), which it modifies. Likewise, in the modified proposition [6a] (“The essence A is a [certain] *essence*”), “essence” takes the place of “thing” in proposition [6] (“The essence A is a *thing*”).

status of a property.²⁰ In this section Avicenna strongly emphasizes the stability of the connection of “thing” and “existent”. He says that this connection is not interrupted under any circumstance (“at all”), and that it is permanent (“always”, section [a]). He also contends that, if a “thing” didn’t exist, it wouldn’t be a “thing” (section [b]). This suggests that existence (i.e. the fact of being an “existent”) is a very peculiar inseparable concomitant of essence (i.e. the fundamental ingredient of a “thing”) and approaches the status of a constitutive element.

3. “Thing” (Essence) and “Existent” (Existence)

Are Distinct from, but Inseparably Related to, One Another

In chapter I, 5, Avicenna insists not only on the difference and the distinction, but also, with equal emphasis, on the connection between “thing” and “existent”, essence and existence. *Prima facie*, Text 1 gives a different impression, since its two main sections argue extensively for the distinction of these items, whereas only the final, much shorter, section points at their connection. Moreover, the relationship of concomitance that Avicenna affirms between “thing” and “existent” in the third section is in a way uneven, since it implies that “existent” inseparably follows “thing”, without entailing a similar concomitance of “thing” with regard to “existent”. This unidirectional, rather than bidirectional, link might suggest a sort of unbalanced relationship between the two concepts.

This impression, however, is misleading. First of all, section [2.3] is not just an appendix of Text 1, as it might seem. It is rather the

²⁰ Further remarks on the concept of *lāzim* in general and on existence as *lāzim* of things can be found in the *Madḥal*, the reworking of Porphyry’s *Isagoge* in the *Šifā’*. See *aš-Šifā’, al-Mantiq, al-Madḥal*, eds. Ġ. Š. Qanawāti, M. al-Ḥuḍayrī and A. F. al-Ahwānī (Cairo: al-Maṭba’a al-Amīriyya, 1952), I, 11, p. 64, 4–9: “As under a *species specialissima* (*naw’ al-anwā*) there are universal subjects, although they are not species, like “secretary”, “sailor”, and “Turk” under “man”, likewise it is not impossible that, above a *summum genus* (*ġins al-aġnās*) there are predicates that are not genera, but notions that are inseparable concomitants (*ma’ānin lāzima*) shared by some of the *summa genera*, like existence and accidentality [*wa-l-‘araḍiyya*; some mss. have instead *wa-l-waḥda* “and unity”, see apparatus ad l. 9], and like some entities that are predicated of a certain number of highest genera (*aġnās ‘āliya*), as you will understand later”. The reference at the end (“as you will understand later”) is to the reworking of the *Categories* (*Maqūlāt* II, 4), where Avicenna discusses the status of motion as an entity external to the categories and common to three of them (quality, quantity and space).

beginning of the lengthy discussion that Avicenna offers in the following part [3]. The view that Avicenna expounds and rejects in this part is tightly connected with section [2.3]: by postulating a disconnection between “existent” and “thing”, this view represents the denial of the main tenet of section [2.3]. The same applies to the view discussed and rejected by Avicenna in part [7], according to which a same “thing” or essence can cease to exist at some point and start to exist again at a later point, namely, it can be brought back into existence or resuscitated. In other words, Avicenna continues to deal with the topic of section [2.3] in the following dialectical portion of chapter I, 5, which functions as a kind of *destructio*, up until the very end of the chapter, of some relevant opinions that go against the doctrine established in this section. Thus, from the point of view of extension, the treatment of the connection between “thing” and “existence”, and essence and existence, in section [2.3] and in its continuation afterwards is in no way shorter than the treatment of their distinction in sections [2.1–2].²¹

Secondly, in a later passage of chapter I, 5 Avicenna contends that “thing” and “existent” are mutually concomitant, using a reciprocal form of the same verb *lazima* that he has employed to express the concomitance of “existent” with regard to “thing” in Text 1 [2.3a]:

Text 2: *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5, p. 34.9–10 [p. 39.37–9] (Outline 1 [4.1])

Now you have understood in what [the concept of] ‘thing’ differs from the concept of ‘existent’ and of ‘supervening’, even though [‘thing’ and ‘existent’] accompany each other inseparably (*mutalāzimāni*).

This means that, in Avicenna’s opinion, the relationship of concomitance does not simply apply to “existent” with respect to “thing”, but also to “thing” with respect to “existent”. The relationship between these two concepts emerges therefore as perfectly balanced, so that “thing” (and essence) cannot reclaim, in this respect, any priority over “existent” (and existence).

In other words, in chapter I, 5, the main text on the topic, Avicenna stresses, together with the separation, also the link between “thing”

²¹ Section [2.3] is pivotal in the structure of chapter I, 5 in two respects. On the one hand, it connects to each other the two most extensive parts of this chapter, namely the second and the third. On the other hand, it marks the transition from the expositive portion of the chapter (parts [1]–[2]) to dialectical portion (parts [3]–[4] and [7]).

and “existent”, and, implicitly, between essence and existence. The two aspects—distinction and connection—appear to be equally important for Avicenna. To pay exclusive attention to, or emphasize the relevance of, the former over the latter seems to be a patent transgression of Avicenna's explicit pronouncement on the issue.

4. *The Issue of Logical Priority*

The second formulation of the distinction of essence and existence¹ in Text 1 discloses an obvious sense in which essence is logically prior to existence: if I cannot know a triangle without knowing its essence, whereas I can know it without knowing its existence¹, it seems evident that essence possesses some kind of logical priority over existence¹. The first formulation of the distinction, on the other hand, seems to envisage a more equal logical status both of essence with respect to existence¹, and of “thing” with respect to “existent”, and even points to the priority of the latter concepts with respect to the former from the logical point of view. Let us therefore consider both formulations together.

What chapter I, 5 says about the intension (i.e. the conceptual content) of “existent” and “thing”, existence and essence, can be summarized in the following table.

Table 1. Avicenna's Remarks on the Intension of “Existent” and “Thing” in *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5

	“Existent”	“Thing”
synonymous with	“established” (<i>muṭbat</i>), “realized” (<i>muḥaṣṣal</i>) [2.2.1b] “supervening” (<i>ḥāṣil</i>) [3.2.1] (p. 32.18)	“entity” (<i>amr</i>), “what” (<i>mā</i>), “that which” (<i>alladī</i>) [2.1d]
conveys the notion of	existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality] (= existence ¹) [2.2.1d] existence synonymous with “being established [in reality]” (= existence ¹) [2.2.2a]	essence = proper existence (= existence ²) ≠ existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality] (= existence ¹) [2.2.1d] proper essence = quiddity ≠ existence synonymous with “being established [in reality]” (= existence ¹) [2.2.2a]

Two features are noteworthy. First, the meaning of “existent” is clarified only by means of synonyms in the first formulation (section [2.2.1b]; another synonym of “existent” is mentioned in section [3.2.1]). The cognate notion of existence¹ makes its appearance in the context of the explanation of the meaning of “thing”, both in the first and in the second formulation (sections [2.2.1d], [2.2.2a]), but is not directly linked to “existent”, although it is obviously related to it. The meaning of “thing”, on the contrary, is not explained by means of synonyms (which are taken into account earlier in section [2.1d] to explain the impossibility of defining “thing”), but by reference to a different notion, that of “essence” and the synonyms of this latter ([2.2.1d], [2.2.2a]). In this regard, “existent” appears to be a concept “more primary”, so speak, than “thing”, since it is less amenable to being explained by different notions.

Second, in the first formulation of the distinction, essence is identified with a second meaning of existence, i.e. “proper existence” or existence² ([2.2.1d]; see above, section 2, Outline 2). This implies that, according to Avicenna, the concept of essence can be intensionally assimilated to the concept of existence¹, insofar as it also conveys the idea of existence. True, the notion of existence (= existence²) conveyed by the essence is not the same notion of existence (= existence¹) conveyed by the concept “existent;” nonetheless, essence is reducible to the general concept of existence, of which existence¹ represents another instance. The concept of existence¹, on the contrary, is introduced by Avicenna with involvement of one of the synonyms of “existent” (“existence regarding the fact of being established [in reality]”, [2.2.1d]; “existence synonymous with being established [in reality]”, [2.2.2a]), but totally independently of the concept of essence.²² In this regard, also existence appears to be a concept “more primary” than essence given that it is not assimilated to other alien notions.

How explain this ambivalent perspective within one and the same text? Two different senses of logical priority may be involved. Essence may be taken as prior to existence with respect to our knowledge of a knowable item like the triangle, since it is more fundamental than existence from the cognitive point of view. Absolutely speaking,

²² Likewise, the intension of “existent” cannot be reduced or assimilated in any way to the intension of “thing”; see *Ilāhīyāt* III, 2, p. 103.8–9 [p. 114.19–20]: “[“One” and “existent”] coincide, insofar as none of them signify the substance (*ḡawhar*) of anything, as you know.” In this text, the term “substance” is obviously synonym of “essence”.

however, i.e. independently from the role played by essence and existence as cognitive tools in the human mind, the domain of essence is not necessarily prior to the domain of existence, and this latter might even be assumed as more primary than the former.

5. *The Issue of Extension*

The extensional relation of “existent” and “thing” in the *Ilāhīyāt* is sufficiently clear. In section [1.3] of chapter I, 5, as well as elsewhere, both concepts, together with the other primary notions, are portrayed as universal:²³ their common universality seems to imply that they have the same extension. The co-extensionality of “existent” and “thing” is confirmed by passages like Text 2, where Avicenna states their co-implication. In the present section, I would like to emphasize two points: first, negatively, that “thing” is not more extensive than “existent” according to Avicenna; second, positively, that “existent” might be even viewed by Avicenna as more extensive than “thing”. Chapters of the *Ilāhīyāt* other than I, 5 provide valuable indications in both these directions.

As to the first point, Avicenna in this work expressly declares that no concept is more universal than “existent”:

Text 3: *Ilāhīyāt* I, 2, p. 14.6 [p. 14.55]:

There is nothing more common than ‘existent’.

A statement like this clearly rules out the possibility of assigning to “thing” an extension greater than “existent”.

Even more—and this is my second point—it would seem that, according to Avicenna, whereas every “thing” is an “existent” (i.e. it exists either in reality or in the mind, as we have seen), not every existent is a “thing”. The reason is that for Avicenna there is at least a being (i.e. God, the Necessary Existent) that is properly an existent, without however being a “thing”. But if this is the case, then “existent” is more extensive than “thing”. Let us see more precisely why.

By gathering together Avicenna’s scattered remarks in chapter I, 5, one gets the following description of “existent”:

²³ Cp. I, 8, p. 54.13–4 [pp. 63.10–64.11]: “...since ‘existent’ is a nature that can be predicated of everything”; II, 2, p. 68.3–4 [p. 78.64–6], where Avicenna states that the fact of being an “entity” (*amr*)—a synonym of “thing” (see above, Table 1)—is “common” (*āmm*), i.e. universal.

Existent_{descr.}: “The established [in reality] (/“The realized”) according to some kind of existence¹”

Likewise, on the basis of the aforementioned evidence, one can formulate the following description of “thing”²⁴:

Thing_{descr.}: “That which (/Entity that /What) has an essence (/a quiddity).”

According to the distinction of essence and existence¹ established in Text 1, the description of “thing” proposed by Avicenna can be rephrased as follows:

Thing_{descr.a}: “That which has an essence *distinct from existence*¹.”

According to these descriptions, one can safely contend that, according to Avicenna, God is an “existent” but is not a “thing”. God is an “existent” since God fully instantiates the aforementioned description of this concept.²⁵ But God, in Avicenna’s view, does not have an essence distinct from existence¹, and therefore is not a “thing”. The relevant statements on the matter occur in *Ilāhiyāt* VIII, 4. It is not clear whether in this chapter Avicenna endorses the thesis that God has no essence distinct from existence (in the sense of existence¹), thus assuming a sort of coincidence of essence and existence in God, or the much stronger position that God has no essence at all.²⁶ Regardless

²⁴ See the similar descriptions in D. L. Black, “Avicenna on the Ontological and Epistemic Status of Fictional Beings,” *Documenti e Studi sulla Tradizione Filosofica Medievale* 8 (1997), 425–53 (at 450), and Druart [2001], 132.

²⁵ The concept “existent” is applied to God, for example, in VIII, 1, p. 327.5 [p. 376.6]; VIII, 3, p. 342.8–9 [p. 396.21–2].

²⁶ The issue is debated: see Goichon [1937], 177, 343–54; E. M. Macierowski, “Does God have a quiddity according to Avicenna?” *The Thomist* 52 (1988), 79–87; J. P. Rosheger, “Is God a ‘What’? Avicenna, William of Auvergne, and Aquinas on the Divine Essence,” in *Medieval Philosophy and the Classical Tradition in Islam, Judaism and Christianity*, ed. J. Inglis (London-New York: Routledge, 2002), 277–96; R. Acar, *Talking about God and Talking about Creation. Avicenna’s and Thomas Aquinas’ Positions*, (Leiden-Boston: Brill, 2005), 81–3. Avicenna’s own words support both alternatives. Text 8 below, for example, supports the first alternative. Likewise, in a later passage of the same chapter VIII, 4 (p. 347.10–12 [p. 402.48–51]), Avicenna contends that the First has no quiddity at all, and opposes It to the other things having quiddities. That God has no essence whatsoever is congruent with Avicenna’s subsequent contention in the same chapter that He has no genus, differentia and definition (*Ilāhiyāt* VIII, 4, pp. 347.17–348.5 [pp. 402.61–403.70]), and is repeated *expressis verbis* also later on in the *Ilāhiyāt* (IX, 1, p. 373.5 [p. 434.5]), and in other works by Avicenna (*Ta’līqāt*, ed. ‘A. Badawī [Cairo: Al-Hay’at al-Misriyya al-‘Amma li-l-Kitāb, 1973], 37.4–7: “Don’t you see that those who truly verify things (*al-muḥaqqiqīna*), in order to get the knowledge of the Necessary Existent by Itself, and of the fact that It is not a body, follow a different procedure? They say: The Necessary Existent by Itself does not have

of Avicenna's precise conception of the relationship of essence and existence in God, it seems clear that, in his perspective, God cannot be a "thing". For, according to the description of this concept provided before, a "thing" must possess an essence, and its essence must be distinct from existence¹. Now, Avicenna's God does not meet at least one of these two requirements, namely the second, possibly even the first. God, therefore, is not a "thing" in Avicenna's view.

But, if this is so, then the extension of "existent" is greater than the extension of "thing". Having a broader scope than "thing", and being a more universal concept, "existent" is therefore prior to "thing" in extension. Thus, the universality in extension that Avicenna ascribes to both "existent" and "thing" in chapter I, 5 and elsewhere, and their co-implication that he maintains in Text 2, do not seem to entail an absolute extensional equivalence.²⁷ In other words, according to Avicenna, the concept of "thing" would be universal in comparison to all the other non-transcendental concepts, but less universal, so-to-speak than "existent"; conversely, the concept of "existent" would be co-extensive with the concept of "thing" in the majority of cases, but not in all.

[...]

a quiddity (*māhiya*); but every body has a quiddity and receives [its] existence from outside; therefore, the Necessary Existent is not a body"). Elsewhere in the *Ilāhiyāt*, on the contrary, Avicenna describes God's nature with expressions that seem to imply His possession of an essence: see, for example, *ḥaqīqat wāḡib al-wuḡūd* ("the essence of the Necessary Existent") in *Ilāhiyāt* VIII, 5, p. 349.11 [p. 405.7] (*ḥaqīqat* is replaced by *dāt* in the following lines), p. 349.17 [p. 405.18–9]; p. 350.3 [p. 406.23] (reading *ḥaqīqatu l-wāḡibi l-wuḡūdi* instead of *ḥaqīqatu l-wāḡibi l-wuḡūdu*).

²⁷ The relationship of unidirectional concomitance that Avicenna affirms between "existent" and "thing" in Text 1 [2.3b] is compatible with a scenario in which "existent" has a greater extension than "thing". What Avicenna says in this passage is that the status of "thing" implies the concomitance of "existent", since every "thing" is in fact an "existent", insofar as it possesses some kind of existence¹ either in the mind or in external objects. He does not contend, however, the reciprocal point, namely that the status of "existent" implies the concomitance of "thing", so that every "existent" would in fact possess an essence and be therefore a "thing". This leaves the possibility open that, whereas all "things" are "existents", not all "existents" are "things".

Finally, in chapter VIII, 4, Avicenna wants to show that the First Principle (the Necessary Existent)⁴¹ has no quiddity, namely essence, other than that-ness (*annīya*), namely existence (no essence at all). In order to do so, he points out that the distinction of essence and existence in the things to which this distinction applies requires the presence of a cause that “mediates” between essence and existence by conferring existence to essence. However, since the First Principle has no cause, It cannot rely on a cause conferring existence to Its essence, and cannot therefore be affected by any distinction of essence and existence.

Text 7: *Ilāhīyāt* VIII, 4, pp. 344.10–1 ([a]); 346.13–347.2 ([b])
[pp. 398.83–399.84; 401.33–6]

[a] The First has no quiddity (*māhīya*) other than that-ness (*annīya*). You have already known, at the beginning of this our clarification, the notion of “quiddity”, and that by which it is distinct (*tufāriqu*) from that-ness in the things in which it is distinct from it. [...]

[b] We say: that-ness and existence are two things that occur accidentally (*‘arīḍāni*) to the quiddity.⁴² Therefore, either they accompany it inseparably (*yalzamuhā*) on account of [the quiddity] itself, or on account of something external. But it is impossible that this happens on account of the quiddity itself, since what follows [something else] does not follow except [something] existent; in this case, therefore, quiddity would have an existence before its existence, which is impossible.

⁴⁰ The “existence that is proper” mentioned by Avicenna here is not the “proper existence” of Text 1, namely the essence; it is rather the existence that is particular, as opposed to the existence that is common, i.e. the universal existence.

⁴¹ VIII, 4, p. 343.9 [p. 397.53–4].

⁴² *al-annīya wa-l-wuḡūd ‘arīḍāni li-l-māhīyati (al-annīya wa-l-wuḡūd law šārā ‘arīḍayni li-l-māhīyati* ed.)

[Therefore they accompany inseparably the quiddity on account of something external, i.e. a cause].

[c] We say: everything having a quiddity other than that-ness is caused. For you know that that-ness and existence, with regard to the quiddity that is external to that-ness, do not have the status of a constitutive entity, but are among the inseparable concomitants (*lawāzim*).

Text 1 is recalled in section [c] ("For you know that..."), and possibly also in section [a] ("You have already known...").⁴³ Of Text 1, section [a] recounts the distinction between essence and existence, named respectively "quiddity" (*māhiya*) and "that-ness" (*annīya*). In section [b], the connection of essence and existence is described by means of the participle of the verb "occur accidentally". The accidentality mentioned here, however, has to be understood as logical, rather than metaphysical, as its immediate replacement with the idea of inseparable concomitance in sections [b] and [c] makes clear.⁴⁴ Section [c] explains the logical accidentality of existence with respect to essence, stressing the status of that-ness and existence as other, external, and non-constitutive with respect to quiddity and essence, and their condition of being inseparable concomitants of the quiddity and essence.

If we compare these other texts of the *Ilāhiyāt* on the relationship of "thing" and "existent", essence and existence, with the main text on the issue, namely chapter I, 5, we notice three important points. First of all, Avicenna is expounding in all cases the *same* doctrine, i.e. a coherent and already established theory, as witnessed by the references to chapter I, 5 in Texts 6 and 7. This attests to the consistency of his overall account and corroborates the status of I, 5 as the main text on the topic. Second, in all these other texts Avicenna recounts only *a part* of chapter I, 5: the texts discussed here repeat various aspects of

⁴³ The terminology of section [a], and the expression "the beginning of this our clarification" occurring at its end, might refer to the beginning of the *Šifā'*, i.e. to its logical part, rather than to the beginning of the *Ilāhiyāt*. See *Madḥal* I, 5, p. 29.11–3, where Avicenna opposes "quiddity", on the one hand, and "individual that-ness" (*annīya šaḥṣiya*), namely the concrete existence of an individual, on the other (the term *annīya* here, however, might also be read as *ayyīya*, "distinctive quality"). See also the passages of *Burhān* discussed by A. Hasnawi, "*Annīya* ou *Innīya* (essence, existence)," in *Encyclopédie philosophique universelle*, Publié sous la direction d'A. Jacob, vol. II: *Les notions philosophiques* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1990), 101–2 (at 101b).

⁴⁴ "To occur accidentally" is one of the verbs employed in Text 4 (see above, n. 37). The Arabic of Text 7 [b] presents many variants in the manuscripts. In the reading adopted in the Cairo edition (see above, n. 42), the status of that-ness and existence as entities that occur accidentally to the quiddity, is an hypothesis to be discarded ("were that-ness and existence two things occurring accidentally to quiddity").

chapter I, 5 (significantly the *locus classicus* of chapter V, 1 is the more scanty in this regard), but none of them reproduces all the motives of this chapter. Thus, Avicenna summarizes the second formulation of the distinction in Text 1 [2.2.2] (in all texts), and the brief account of the relationship of “thing” and “existent” in section [2.3] (in some texts), whereas he skips the first formulation of the distinction in section [2.2.1], and the additional considerations on the relationship of “thing” and “existent” after Text 1. Consequently, all hints to the logical priority of existence and “existent” with respect to essence and “thing” in the first formulation are neglected. As in the second formulation, the distinction between these two pairs of concepts, rather than their intimate connection, is underscored; where their relationship is discussed, “existent” and existence are invariably characterized as attributes of “thing” and essence, not vice versa. This happens because Avicenna’s specific goal in these passages is to distinguish a certain nature from its universality (Texts 4–5), to distinguish the rank of importance of the causes from the rank of their concrete existence, in order to explain the peculiar status of the final cause (Text 6), and to distinguish God as the only being, in which essence is identical to existence from all the other caused beings, in which essence is other than existence (Text 7). Thirdly, these texts do not disprove the features of chapters I, 5 that they do not recount, namely the suggestion that Avicenna in *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 would be alluding to the dependence—both intensional and extensional—of essence and “thing” on existence and “existent”, and would be assuming a reciprocal, bi-directional connection of these two pairs of concepts. These features far from being contradicted, simply lie outside the limited scope of investigation proper of these texts.

[...]

⁴⁵ Goichon [1937], 131, sees an increasing importance ascribed by Avicenna throughout his career to the distinction, this latter remaining however substantially unmodified. The evolution that Wisnovsky [2003], 173–80, traces in Avicenna’s standpoint on essence and existence regards, on the one hand, the late application of the

Conclusion

The aim of the previous pages was to contextualize more precisely Avicenna's doctrine of essence and existence, in order to show its complexity and elucidate its constituents. Avicenna's actual account of this doctrine appears to be multifaceted and more complex than it is usually described in secondary literature. In particular, I have tried to supplement the scholarship on this doctrine in three main respects. First, I have strived to redirect attention to the most important text by Avicenna on the distinction at hand, namely chapter I, 5 of the *Ilāhīyāt*. A careful examination of this chapter discloses two further aspects in which secondary literature appears unbalanced: it too harshly portrays the distinction of essence and existence as a sort of radical separation between these two items; and it is one-sided in ascribing to essence priority over existence, while also attributing to the concept of "thing" an analogous priority, both intensional and extensional, with regard to the concept of "existent". In all these respects, scholarship to date relies on Avicenna's doctrine of universals in *Ilāhīyāt* V, 1–2, paying relatively less attention to his doctrine of the primary concepts or transcendentals in *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 (section 1 above).

The analysis of *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 provided here (section 2 above) discloses a different scenario. The distinction of essence and existence, "thing" and "existent", in this chapter does not appear as a sharp dichotomy. On the contrary, Avicenna stresses and defends against opposite views the inseparable connection between "thing" and "existent", essence and existence, portraying this link as mutual and as required for the status of "thing". This being the case, essence can hardly be said to be "neutral" or "indifferent" towards existence in general, although it may be loosely linked to particular instances of existence, such as its existence in the mind as a universal concept. On account of this, Avicenna's doctrine deserves to be labelled "*relationship* of essence and existence", rather than "*distinction* of essence and existence", as it is usually called (section 3 above). Essence and existence, "thing" and "existent", have different intensions, and essence and "thing" are surely prior to existence and "existent" from a cognitive point of view; according to an absolute consideration, however, existence and "existent" are intensionally *prior* to essence and "thing", since the meaning of essence is expressed also by a particular sense of existence ("proper existence" or existence²), and "existent" is not susceptible to being explained by means of a different notion, such as by the notion of

essence in the case of “thing” (section 4 above). Moreover, “thing” and “existent” are *grosso modo* co-extensive, but do not have exactly the same extension, insofar as the extension of “existent” encompasses an item that the extension of “thing” does not include; every “thing” is also an “existent”, but not every “existent” is also a “thing”, since God, not having an essence distinct from existence, is an “existent” without being a “thing” (section 5 above). Avicenna’s view of the relationship of “thing” and “existent”, essence and existence, expounded in *Ilāhīyāt* I, 5 is recounted in many other *loci* of this work (section 6 above), as well as elsewhere (section 7 above). All the available textual evidence points at a single, coherent doctrine, although the distinctive aspects of chapter I, 5 are not recounted in the additional texts; these texts thus ground and corroborate the aforementioned *versio vulgata*.

In chapter I, 5 (the main text on the issue), in other words Avicenna’s discussion of the relationship of “thing” and “existent”, essence and existence, appears to be motivated by a peculiar intention: to stress that “existent” and existence are, at least in some respects, logically prior and more universal than “thing” and essence, and to safeguard this tenet in the context of a doctrine that, in fact, points in the opposite direction. This emphasis on the primacy of “existent” and existence represents a unique case among the various treatments of essence and existence in Avicenna’s *œuvre*. If we consider that in the previous chapters of the *Ilāhīyāt* Avicenna has proved that “existent” is the subject-matter of metaphysics, and that in the same context he is equally subordinating to “existent”, in different ways and respects, also the other primary concepts taken into account in the *Ilāhīyāt* (“necessary” is defined in term of “existence” in I, 5; both “necessary” and “one” are described as properties of “existent” in I, 2), this tendency to underscore the priority of “existent” with respect to “thing” appears to be part of a general strategy that aims at showing that “existent” is the first and most universal among the primary concepts, and that hence it solely deserves to be the subject-matter of the first and most universal science.⁴⁸

⁴⁸ See A. Bertolacci, “‘Necessary’ as Primary Concept in Avicenna’s Metaphysics”, in *Conoscenza e contingenza nella tradizione aristotelica medievale*, eds. G. Fioravanti and S. Perfetti (Pisa: ETS, 2008), 31–50. A thorough account of Avicenna’s doctrine of the primary concepts in the *Ilāhīyāt*, as well as of its Latin reception, will be provided by the author in *The Arabic Sources of Albertus Magnus’ Commentary on the Metaphysics: Avicenna and Averroes* (in progress).